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(*c.* AD 750–1300)

(Regional Powers and Their Interactions)

Editors

Dilip K. Chakrabarti and Makkhan Lal

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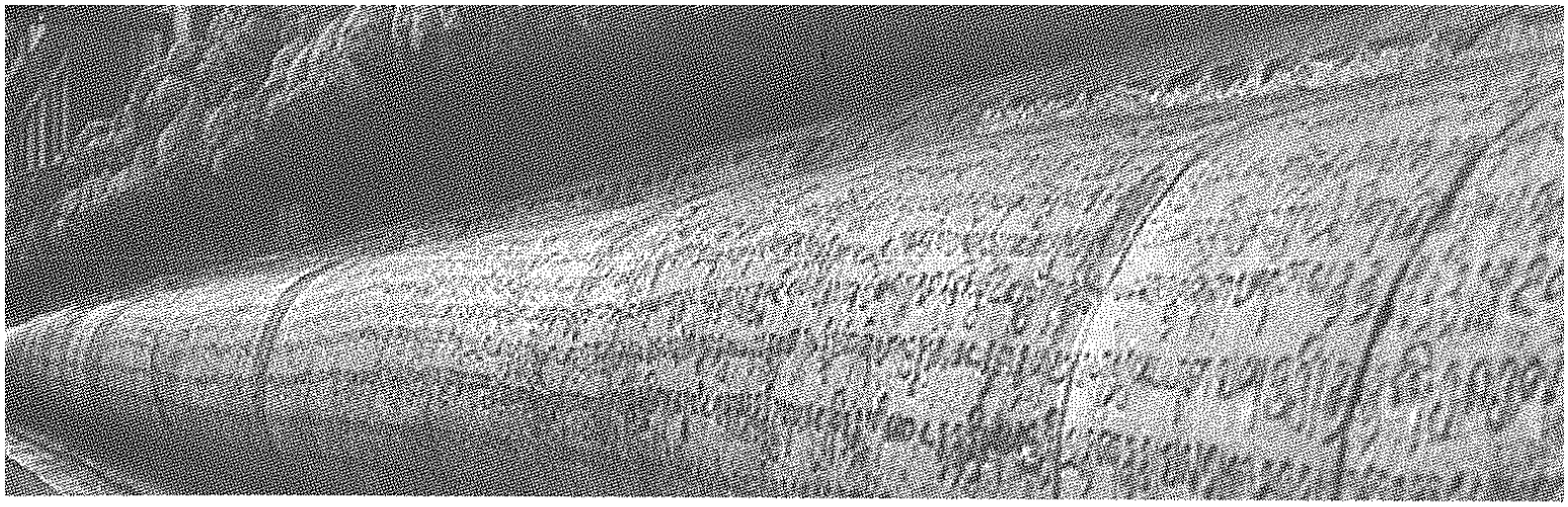
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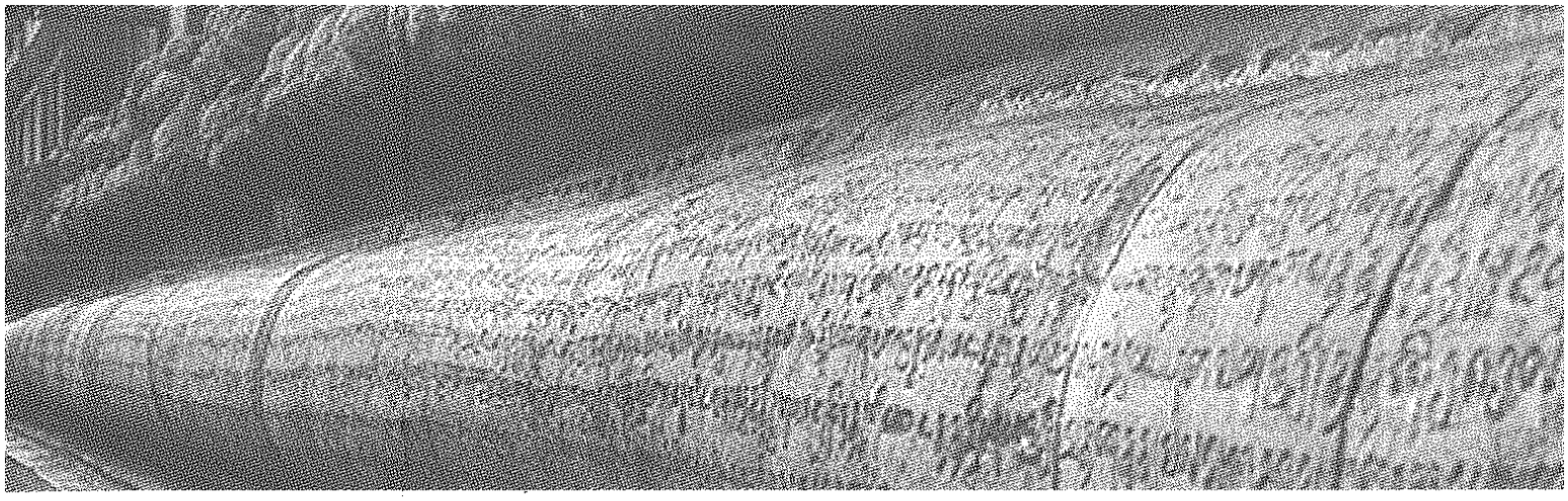
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I.1. The Gurjara Pratiharas

Editorial Note

[Whether the present group of the Gujjars can be related to the ancient Gurjara dynasty may be discussed *ad finitum* but without any conclusive result. There is also not an iota of positive evidence that they represent any non-Indian group of people. What remains a historical fact, however, is that this dynasty had under its influence a vast stretch of India from Malwa and Rajasthan to the southern section of the Ganga Valley, with control over Kanauj. Of all the Rajasthan-Malwa dynasties, this seems to be the most powerful one.]

The Gurjaras came into prominence about the second half of the sixth century AD. They formed an ethnic group, which spread over different parts of north India, and lent their name to different localities at different times. The first Gurjara kingdom was founded in Rajputana near Jodhpur. The place-names like Gujranwala, Gujar-Khan, Gujarat in Punjab, Gujargarh in the northern part of former Gwalior state, Gujarat as another name of the district of Saharanpur in the 18th century AD have all been taken to mark the different settlements of the Gurjaras in the ancient period. This inference seems to be corroborated by the present distribution of the Gurjaras who are widely spread in the whole of north-western India, western Himalayan region, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, western Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Indus Valley region.

ORIGIN OF THE GURJARAS

The Gurjara clan seems to have come into existence in north India about 6th century AD; after the invasions of the Hunas. They were primarily classed as Kshatriyas and Brahmins.

Many Gurjara records claim descent from Suryavanshi Kshatriyas and that the Gurjaras were sun-worshippers. Their copperplate grants bear an emblem of the Sun, and on their seals, too, this symbol is depicted. Also the Gurjara title of honour is Mihir, which means sun. The poet Rajasekhara in his plays styled Gurjara rulers as *Raghu-Kula-Tilaka, Raghu-gramani.* V.A. Smith believed that Gurjaras were foreign immigrants, probably a branch of white Hunas. D.R. Bhandarkar believed that the Gurjaras came into India with the Hunas, and their name Gurjar was sanskritized to Gurjara or Gujara. He also believed that several places in Central Asia, such as Gurjistan, are named after the Gurjaras and that the reminiscences of Gurjara migration is preserved in these names.

Some scholars have identified the Gurjaras with Yuezhi or Tocharians of Indo-Scythian stock. In the past, Gurjaras have also been hypothesized to be descended from the nomadic Khazar tribes and linked through them to Central Asia. The ancient localities bearing names derived from Gurjara and the distribution of the modern Gurjars, have led many scholars to regard the Gurjaras as foreign people who came to India, along with Hunas, through the north-western passes and gradually spread towards south and east—the stages of their advance being roughly marked by the localities named after them throughout north India.

This view of foreign origin of Gurjaras is not shared by all. Some scholars are of the opinion that Gurjara was primarily the name of the country and not of a people. It has even been suggested that the various localities bearing names derived from the word 'Gurjara' were originally parts of a large homogeneous territory called Gurjaradesa and now represent merely isolated fragments of it.

GURJARA KINGDOM OF JODHPUR

The earliest kingdom of Gurjara was founded by Harichandra in the modern Jodhpur state in Rajaputana about the middle of 6th century AD. The early history of this family is recorded in an inscription found at Jodhpur.[1] This inscription refers to a line of twelve kings. It first traces the origin of the Pratihara clan to the epic hero Lakshmana. Harichandra Rohilladdhi was referred to as a Brahmana. He was well-versed in the Vedas and other religious scriptures. He had two wives; the first one was Brahmana and the second wife a Kshatriya lady named Bhadra. The sons born to his Brahmana wife became Pratihara Brahmana, while the sons born to his Kshatriya wife came to be known as Pratihara. He had four sons by his Kshatriya wife, who were fit to hold the earth, who conquered the fort of Mandavyapura and erected there a high rampart.[2] One of these sons was Rajjila, whose grandson Nagabhata fixed his capital at the great city of Medantaka. The inscription then gives a brief history of the family up to Bauka, eighth in descent from Harichandra. It is dated and the year is most probably AD 837 (VS 894). Kakkuka, the younger brother of Bauka, has also left an inscription dated AD 861. As these two brothers represent the twelfth generation of kings, the foundation of the dynasty may be placed at about AD 550.[3]

It is clear from the record that Harichandra began his career as a learned Pandit but took advantage of the political condition caused by the downfall of the Gupta empire to carve out a small principality for himself. There was nothing very unusual for the Brahmana exchanging *Sastra* (Scripture) for the *Sastra* (sword). A similar example is furnished by Mayursarman who founded the Kadamba dynasty.

The first fortified settlement of the family, Mandavyapura, is identified with Mandor, five miles to the north of Jodhpur. *Madantaka*, the

capital city of Nagabhata, is most probably identified with Merta, seventy miles north-east of Jodhpur. This Gurjara kingdom founded by Harichandra lasted for more than three hundred years, i.e. from the middle of the sixth to the middle of the ninth century AD. Banabhatta in his *Harshacharita* mentions that the advance of the Gurjaras to this region brought them into conflict with Prabhakaravardhana, the ruler of Thanesvar.

GURJARA KINGDOM OF BROACH/LATA

The existence of the Broach line of the Gurjaras is recorded in several inscriptions.[4] Their territory extended from Mahi River to Kim River, known as the central Lata region. The first three rulers of this line were Dadda I, his son Vitaraga Jayabhata I and his son Dadda II Prasantaraga. The known dates of Dadda II Prasantaraga are AD 629 to 641. The date of Dadda I may be put in the last quarter of sixth century AD.[5] He is said to have been born in the family of the Gurjara kings (*Gurjara-nripativamsa*) and may, therefore, be identified with Dadda—one of the four sons of Harichandra, the founder of Gurjara kingdom in Jodhpur. The inscription of Dadda II indicates that his kingdom presumably extended from the Mahi River in the north to the Kim River in the south and from sea-coast on the west to the borders of Malwa and Khandesh in the east. The city of Nandipuri, from which both his inscriptions were issued, was presumably his capital.[6] The contemporary evidence suggests that the region of Lata was part of Kalachuri kings—Buddhiraja and Sankaragana. This line of Gurjara family seems to have been *samanta* of Kalachuri Kings. Dadda I and Dadda II styled themselves as *samanta*, while Jayabhata assumed the higher epithet of *Mahasamanta* and *Samadhigata Pancamahasabda*.

In the inscriptions of the Gurjaras of Broach, Dadda II was glorified as the real architect of the kingdom in the Lata country and heads the genealogy in all later records.[7] The next ruler of the family was Jayabhata II who probably ruled around AD 645–65 and paid tribute to the Vallabhi king Dharasena.[8]

Dadda III, the successor of Jayabhata and who assumed the title of *Panchamahasabda*, is said to have conquered the kings of the east and the west.[9] This might have been a retaliatory move against the Maitrakas of Valabhi. In his time, the Gurjara Kingdom was attacked by a ruler named Vajrata, mentioned in the Nasik plates of Dharasraya Jayasimha. This attack was repulsed with the help of the Chalukya king and the whole army of Vajrata was destroyed in the region between Mahi and the Narmada by Jayasimha, a younger brother of Pulakesin II. The reigning period of Dadda III may be fixed between AD 665 and 690. His successor was Jayabhata III, who probably flourished between AD 690 and 715. He is known to us from two records—the Nausari Plates and the Anjaneri plates.[10] He was called *Mahasamantadhipati* in the records of his successors. He was succeeded by his son Ahirola who ruled probably from AD 715–720. The next ruler was Jayabhata IV, who is known from his two copperplates. The Kavi copperplate dated AD 736 implies that he inflicted a defeat on the contemporary rulers of Valabhi.[11] V.V. Mirashi interpreted this with the help of better preserved Prince of Wales Museum plates, which show that Jayabhata IV went to the rescue of the king of Valabhi, when his capital was attacked by the Tajjikas or Arabs and inflicted a crushing defeat on them. This event might be placed between AD 720–735, when the Arabs were following a vigorous expansion policy under the governorship of Junaid and attacked Vallabhi. Jayabhata IV

probably joined hands with the Maitraka rulers against the Arabs and defeated them. The Arabs did not take the defeat lightly. They avenged it, by overrunning the kingdom of Jayabhata himself. The Gurjara kingdom of Broach was thereafter annexed by the Chalukyas of Gujarat.[12]

The Gurjaras of Broach ruled for six generations that comprise the period of about one hundred and twenty years with their capital first at Nandipuri (Nandod) and later on at Bharukaccha (Broach).

GURJARA-PRATIHARA OF KANAUJ

The dynasty which was destined to raise the Gurjara power to the height of its glory flourished some time later in the region of Ujjain and Kanauj. This dynasty called itself Pratiharas. Epigraphic records have led scholars to assume that these Pratiharas were a clan of the Gurjara tribe.[13] The word 'Pratihara' means a door-keeper. Scholars believe that this name connects them with the epic hero Lakshmana, who served as a doorkeeper to his brother Rama. This proves a belief in the common origin of the Kshatriya and Brahmana Pratiharas of Jodhpur and the Imperial Pratiharas of Kanauj.

NAGABHAT I

The Imperial Pratihara family was founded by Nagabhata in the first half of the eighth century AD. It eclipsed the power and glory of the other Pratihana families and raised the name and fame of their clan to a height of greatness. The ancestry of this family is described and preserved in the Gwalior *prasasti* of Bhoja, the seventh king of the dynasty.[14] The Gwalior inscription begins with a reference to the epic where Lakshamana was the doorkeeper to his elder brother Rama on a memorable occasion and then Nagabhata was born in his line. This Nagabhata defeated the powerful forces of a *mlechchha* king. This may denote an Arab invasion sometime around AD 725. His kingdom, in all probability, was somewhere in Avanti or Malwa with his capital at Ujjayini.[15]

The political situation in western India was gloomy and disturbed because of Arab invasions. The Arabs conquered the region of Sind, advanced into the interior of India and conquered several kingdoms in western region, i.e. Gujarat and Rajasthan. Nausari plates[16] described the victories of Arab forces over the Saindhavas, the Kachchhellas, the Chavatakas, the Mauryas, the Gurjaras and the kingdom of Saurashtra, but their progress further south was checked by the defeat they suffered at the hands of Avanijanasraya Pulakesiraja, the Chalukya ruler of Gujarat. The Arab historian Baladhuri also gives an account of the victorious expedition of the Arabs in the course of which they advanced as far as Broach in the south and Ujjain in the east. It is, however, significant that according to Baladhuri, the Arabs could not achieve any success in their expedition against Ujjain, the capital of Avanti. He records the details that Junaid, the general of Caliph Hashan (AD 724–43), made extensive conquests and sent officers against Ujjain and the country of Maliba (Malwa). Tamim, who succeeded Junaid (AD 726), was feeble and in his days the Musalmans retreated from several parts of India.[17] It would appear that shortly after AD 724 the Arabs, from their secure base in Sindh, sent one or more expeditions in the interior of India and defeated a number of kingdoms. But, the Arabs were defeated by Nagabhata, the Pratihara ruler of Malwa and probably sometime later, by the Chalukya king of Gujarat. The defeated kingdoms of western India accepted the suzerainty of Nagabhata I.

The southward extension of the Pratiharas under Nagabhata I brought them into conflict

with the Rashtrakutas. The founder of Rashtrakuta dynasty was Dantidurga who ruled between AD 733 and 758. Their records narrate that he conquered Avanti, Lata and Sindh and performed the *hiranyagarbhadana* ceremony in which a Gurjara king, along with other rulers, was made to serve as *Pratihara* or door-keeper.[18] The Gurjara king is generally identified with Nagabhata I, who is also said to claim his suzerainty over Lata and Broach. It does not appear that the victory claimed by the Rashtrakuta ruler Dantidurga was either decisive or permanent. It is evident that both Nagabhata I and Dantidurga were the two emerging rulers of north and south. Both of them wanted to take advantage of the troubled political situation caused by the Arabs and came into conflict. Though Dantidurga might have gained some victories at first but he could not achieve any lasting success either in Avanti or Broach, and Nagabhata I's power could not be effectively curbed by the Rashtrakuta ruler. It is interesting to note that the hostile relations between the founders of Rashtrakuta and the Pratihara royal families were the beginning of that hereditary struggle between two dynasties, which continued for two centuries and more than once effectively curbed the powers of Pratiharas. Nagabhata also established his supremacy over the Pratiharas of Jodhpur line, whose power must have been considerably weakened by the disastrous Arab invasions.

Kakkuka and Devraja

Nagabhata I died about AD 760, and left a powerful and extensive kingdom to his brother's son Kakkuka who succeeded him. Kakkuka or Kakutstha and Devaraja or Devasakti probably ruled between *c.* AD 760 and 780 as Devaraja's son Vatsaraja ruled Avanti around AD 783. Nagabhata's successor Kakkuka was a non-entity, who probably ruled for a short time. He died issueless and was succeeded by his younger brother Devaraja or Devasakti. He was a devotee of Vishnu and was married to Bhuyikadevi. The Gwalior *prasasti* of Bhoja describes him as defeating a large number of kings and destroying their powerful allies.[19] This appears exaggerated.

Vatsaraja

Vatsaraja succeeded his father Devaraja as the fourth ruler of Pratihara dynasty. Gwalior *prasasti* describes him as a mighty ruler who had subdued the whole world and was the foremost among the distinguished Kshatriyas.[20] Jain works *Kuvalayamala* and *Harivamsa Purana* refer to Vatsaraja's kingdom as comprising Malwa, Jodhpur and some other parts of Rajasthan, and he ascended the throne in or before AD 778. Daulatpura and Osia inscriptions[21] also furnished information that Vatsaraja ruled over central Rajputana, with other Pratihara families ruling in subordinate position from this region. The Gwalior *prasasti* records that he forcibly wrested the empire from the famous Bhandi clan.[22] This Bhandi clan has been taken by some scholar to refer to the ruling family founded by Bhandi, the maternal uncle of Harsha, though we have no independent evidence of this.[23] *Harivamsa Purana* mentions that Indrayudha, his contemporary in the north, represented imperial power with his seat of authority at Kanauj and that by defeating him, Vatsaraja gained political supremacy of this region. Vatsaraja followed an aggressive imperial policy of establishing an empire in north India. His ambition brought him into conflict with the Pala rulers of Bengal. He attained considerable success in his eastern expansion policy but, unfortunately, the fruits of his victory were snatched away from him by the Rashtrakuta king

Dhruva (AD 779–94). The whole event is described in Radhanpur and Wani copperplates of the Rashtrakuta king Govinda III.[24]

The epigraphic records mentioned in poetic verse that Vatsaraja had attained the position of supremacy by defeating the king of Gauda and then he was defeated at the height of his success by the Rashtrakuta king Dhruva.

Dharmapala, the Gauda king, was the contemporary ruler in the West Bengal region. Vatsaraja invaded the Pala kingdom and in this expedition against Dharmapala of Bengal, he was aided by his ally, the Chahamana Durlabharaja of Sakambhari, who is said to have overrun the whole of Bengal up to the confluence of Ganga and the sea.[25]

While Vatsaraja and Dharmapala were fighting for establishing supremacy over north India, the Rashtrakuta king Dhruva seized the opportunity to emulate Dantidurga by renewing the attempt to conquer the north. The details of his campaign are not known, but, according to Rashtrakuta records, Dhruva inflicted a crushing defeat upon Vatsaraja, who was forced to take shelter in the desert of Rajputana.[26] Vatsaraja probably lost his hold over Malwa and other possessions. Henceforth, Rajaputana formed the centre of his political authority and the chief seat of power of the Pratihara family until, sometime later, it was transferred to Kanauj.[27] Dhruva next turned against Dharmapala and defeated him somewhere between the Ganga and the Yamuna. It is difficult to suggest the probable date of Vatsaraja's death and the time of his son Nagabhata II's accession to the throne. It might be roughly fixed in AD 800 or a few years later.

NAGABHATA II

Nagabhata II succeeded to the throne of Pratihara family in very adverse political conditions. The fortunes of Gurjara dynasty were at their lowest due to the successive defeats at the hands of the Rahtrakutas. At the time of Nagabhata II's succession, Pratihara rule was confined mainly to Rajasthan, the original home of the Gurjaras. Nagabhata II set himself to the task of reviving the fortunes of his family.[28] He made an alliance with the rulers of Andhra, Saindhava, Vidarbha, and Kalinga.[29] He defeated Chakrayudha and the lord of Vanga, and forcibly seized the hill forts of the kings of Anarta, Malava, Kirata, Turushka, Vatsa and Matsya. Rashtrakuta records categorically assert that Nagabhata II was defeated by Govinda III, who overran his dominions and reached the Himalayas.[30]

If we take the events described in Gwalior *prasasti* in chronological order, the first achievement of Nagabhata II was obtaining the submission of the kings of Andhra, Sindh, Vidarbha and Kalinga kingdoms. They seem to have been voluntarily attracted towards him. These kings seem to have joined hands with him in the face of the Rahtrakuta menances from the south, and that of the Palas from the east for supremacy in the north. To these rulers Nagabhata II appeared to be a good leader and natural allies to save their kingdoms from Rashtrakutas and Palas.[31]

The further sequence of events, as recorded in the Gwalior *prasasti* of Bhoja, Nagabhata II seized the hill forts of the king of Anarta, Malwa, Kirata, Turuska, Vastsa and Matsya. The location of these kingdoms would evidently suggest that Nagabhata II's conquest included practically the whole of the present Uttar Pradesh including Mathura and Allahabad districts, certain portion

in eastern U.P., Nepal, Malwa, some portions of Gujarat and some portions of western India then into Arab possession. According to Majumdar, the geographical position of the rulers shows that Nagabhata II advanced towards north and this probably brought him into conflict with the Rashtrakutas.[32]

After consolidating his position and by making good allies, Nagabhata set his eyes to regain Kanuaj. Its ruler Indrayudha had probably acknowledged Vatsaraja's suzerainty and was perhaps, for that very reason, defeated by Dharmapala, who put Chakrayudha on the throne of Kanauj. Nagabhata II defeated Chakrayudha and conquered his kingdom back. It was a blow to the prestige of Pala king Dharampala. The war between Nagabhata and Dharampala became inevitable and both sides made preparations to gain supremacy over each other. Nagabhata was joined by at least three of his allies in this struggle for the empire. These were Kakka, of the Jodhpur Pratihara family, Vahukadhavala, the Chalukya chief of southern Kathiawar, and the Guhilot Sankaragana. The epigraphical records of these kings refer to the battle fought with Gaudas at Monghyr, and having defeated King Dharma, made the whole world, gained by warfare, submitted to his overlord.[33] The records refer to the great battle between Nagabhata and the lord of Vanga, described in the Gwalior inscription. Though there is no reference to this battle in the Pala records, the combined testimony from four different sources leave no doubt that Nagabhata II scored a great victory over Dharmapala.

Once again, the hereditary enemies from the south upset the imperial scheme of the Pratiharas. Nagabhata II came into conflict with the Rashtrakuta king Govinda-III in the early part of his reign. Probably about AD 794-95, Govinda III defeated Nagabhata, who accepted subservient position, but as soon as the Rashtrakuta king turned his back and was engrossed in his Deccan campaign, the Pratihara ruler availed the opportunity, and established his position in north by defeating the Pala king.

The Rashtrakuta king Govinda III could not be content merely with a defensive policy against the Pratiharas. He again made preparations to invade the north as his father Dhruva had done before. Rashtrakuta records inform that Chakrayudha and Dharampala also made an alliance with Govinda III against Nagabhata II, the common enemy. Rashtrakuta records mention that Govinda III defeated Nagabhata and proceeded up to the Himalayas.[34] It is difficult to fix the date of the great victory of Govinda III over Nagabhata II, but it must have taken place around AD 809–10. Nagabhata II's power was not destroyed completely. A record of AD 815 from Jodhpur, gives him all the imperial titles and describes his dominions proper.[35] It leads to the conclusion that Nagabhata II continued to exercise his sway over the greater part of Rajasthan and the Kathiawar Peninsula. In the east, his domain extended up to Gwalior and probably further east so as to include Kanauj and Kalanjara. The work *Prabhavaka Charita* mentions that King Nagavaloka of Kanyakubja, the grandfather of Bhoja, died in VS 890 (AD 833). This Nagavaloka is identified with Nagabhata II. The Jain text also informs that Nagabhata II put an end to his life by immersion in the holy waters of the Ganga.

The reigns of Vatsaraja and Nagabhata II occupy a prominent place in the contemporary history of India.

Rambhadra

Nagabhata II was succeeded by his son Rambhadra, who had a very short and inglorious

reign of probably three years. With Rambhadra ended the first phase of the Gurjara Pratihara history beginning with Nagabhata I. A new imperial phase in the history of Gurjara Pratihara was ushered in by Bhoja, who was probably the greatest ruler of the dynasty.

Bhojadeva (*c.* AD 836–889)

The Barah copperplate, which he issued in AD 836 from his camp at Mahodaya in Kalanjara situated in Banda district in U.P., shows that Bhojadeva had ascended the throne in or before AD 836 and was already in possession of the region around Kalanjar.[36] Bhoja is known to us by several names recorded in his inscriptions as his *birudas* and is also noticed by the Arab historians. These are *Srimad Adivaraha, Maharaja Sri Bhojadeva, Mihira, Parameswara Sri Bhojadeva,* etc.[37]

The regions of Rajasthan and Gujarat were controlled by Bhoja. The Daulatpura copperplate of Bhoja records that a piece of land in Gujarat, the home territory of the Jodhpur Pratiharas, which was originally granted by Vatsaraja and continued by Nagabhata II, fell into abeyance and was renewed by Bhoja in AD 843.[38] This indicates, like the Barah copperplate, that there was obstruction in the enjoyment of land during the reign of Ramabhadra. The record confirms that by AD 843, Bhoja had reasserted his authority over Gujarat and central and eastern Rajaputana. On the basis of the information provided by these inscriptions, it appears that Bhoja was helped by the Chandella, Chahamana and the Rohilladhi Gurjara families in subjugating disruptive forces, which might have raised their heads in the time of Ramabhadra. Chatsu inscription of Baladitya affirms that Harsaraja Guhila conquered kings in the north and presented horses to Bhoja.[39] This ruler seems to be an ally of Bhoja and participated in the campaign on behalf of his overlord. The Pehoa inscription of AD 882 refers to the rule of Bhojadeva in the region of Haryana and Punjab.[40] The Arab historian Suleiman had made an interesting reference to the king of Jurz noted for his riches, and his camels and horses are described as numerous.[41] Pehoa inscription records that Prithudaka was an important centre for horse-trading, while Rajputana was noted for camels. The verses from *Rajatarangini* have been taken by historians to indicate that there was an alliance between the Gurjara king Alakhana and the Adhoraja Bhoja, whose authority he was acknowledging against common enemies.[42] This kingdom of Gurjara king Alakhana is identified with the region of Takka in Jammu, which was invaded by Sankaravarman, the king of Kashmir in the last days of Bhoja's reign when he was preoccupied in the east and could not, therefore, come to the rescue of his subordinate and ally. To preserve the rest of his territory, the Takka king Alakhana gave up the possession of Takka to Sankaravarman. It thus corroborates the assertion that Bhoja's empire extended up to the borders of Sindh and might have even included some parts of it.

The inclusion of Kutch and Kathiawar region in the Gurjara Pratihara empire is referred to in the Una copperplate of the time of Mahendrapala.[43] It appears that Balavarman was a subordinate ally of Bhoja, who helped Bhoja in the conquest of region by slaying enemies mentioned as Visadha and Jajjapa. Bhoja's incursions in central and western India and hold over these regions are also confirmed from other sources as well as from the Pratapgarh inscription of Mahendrapala II.[44] Devgarh inscription also refers to Bhoja's hold over central India.[45]

The Pratihara-Pala relations were not cordial as they were parties to the famous tripartite



Map 1. Extent of the Gurjara Pratihara kingdom (after B.N. Puri 1986).

struggles. The relations between these two northern powers, their mutual clashes and triumphs can be traced from the informations recorded in the Badal and Monghyr records of the Palas,[46] the Gwalior *prasasti* of Bhoja, Chatsu inscription of Baladitya,[47] and the Kahla plates of the Kalachuri king Sodhadeva.[48] The Palas succeeded against the Pratiharas under the weak rule of Ramabhadra. Bhoja seems to have taken revenge of the Pratihara defeat, by crushing the Pala twice—once around AD 845 and then about AD 870. In the first battle, Bhoja was joined by Gunamabodhideva, and they defeated Devapala, the Pala king. The second battle took

place in the time of Vigrahapala, and with the help of the Guhila allies, the Pratihara ruler inflicted a crushing defeat upon his Pala counterpart. The Pratihara hold over Bengal is evident from the findspots of some of the records of Bhoja's reign in the Pala Kingdom.

According to B.N. Puri, the relation between Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas during the reign of Bhoja can be looked upon into three phases. Bhoja's contemporaries were Amoghavarsa and Krisna II.[49] The first phase was marked with inactivity on both the sides—politically as well as militarily. Amoghavarsa, the Rashtrakuta ruler, had to encounter trouble at home as his succession was disputed. He consolidated his position by suppressing revolts and then reconquered the lost territories of his kingdom. The second phase is illustrated by a number of records of the branch line noticing clashes with the Gurjaras. The Bagumara inscription of Dhruva III of the Broach branch of the Rashtrakutas describes the exploits of members of this line against the Gurjaras.[50] Another record from Bagumara refers to reconciliation between the main and the Broach branch of Rashtrakuta lines against common Gurjara enemies of the north.

Rashtrakuta and Pratihara struggle was renewed during the reign of Krishna II. Bhoja probably took the offensive policy and gained considerable success. A Pratihara record refers to the defeat of Krishna II, probably on the banks of the Narmada and his retreat to the south of river.

After having thus occupied Malwa, Bhoja advanced towards Gujarat. The Rashtrakuta records mention that the region around Khetaka (Kaira district) fell into his hands. Though Krishna II reasserted his authority and regained them. A battle between the two took place at Ujjain around AD 878–888. In this battle, Bhoja lost Malwa. Though Pratihara records are silent on this loss, an inscription at Pratapgarh in southern Rajasthan region refers to a local Chahamana dynasty which acknowledged the suzerainty of Pratihara and probably helped them in their wars against the Rashtrakutas. It would thus appear that Malwa formed a part of the Pratihara dominions as late as AD 946.

Although Bhoja lost his hold upon Khitaka or Kaira district (Gujarat), he continued to maintain supremacy over probably the whole of Kathiawar Peninsula.

In the north-west, his dominions extended to the Punjab. In the east, the Kalachuris of Gorakhpur were his subordinate rulers and probably the whole of Awadh was included in his dominions. The Chandellas of Bundelkhand also acknowledged his overlordship. Bhoja thus created and consolidated a large kingdom in northern India. Bhoja had a long reign of 46 years. The earliest known date of Bhoja is AD 836 and 882 is the last known date. The Arab historian Sulaiman refers to the great power and resources of the king of Jurz as they called Gurjara by this name. Sulaiman records that,

> This King maintains numerous forces and no other Indian prince has so fine a cavalry. He is unfriendly to the Arabs, still he acknowledges that the king of the Arabs is the greatest of kings. Among the princes of India, there is no greater foe to the Muhammadan faith than he. His territories form a tongue of land he has got riches, and his camels and horses are numerous. Exchanges are carried on in his states with silver and gold in dust, and there are said to be mines (of these metals) in the country: There is no country in India more safe from robbers.[51]

The exact date of Bhoja's death and Mahendrapala's accession is uncertain.

Mahendrapala

Bhojadeva was succeeded by his son Mahendrapala. According to Majumdar, he must have ascended the throne in or before AD 893, which is his earliest known date. Mahendrapala had various other names in the records.[52]

The famous epigraphical records of Mahendrapala's reign are Una copperplate inscription[53] dated AD 893–899, Dighwa-Dubauli copperplate[54] dated AD 955, the consolidated Siyadoni inscriptions[55] recording a number of donations from VS 960 (AD 1025) mostly by private persons in favour of various deities, and also a few records of the Kanauj king Mahendrapaladeva.[56] Paharpur (Rajshahi district, Bangladesh) pillar inscription[57] of the time of Mahendrapala, dated in fifth regnal year, records the dedication of the pillar to Lord Buddha by a Buddhist monk.

This inscription is important for extending the eastern boundary of the Pratihara empire as far as north-eastern Bengal. The two other important records are the Rama-Gaya inscription[58] and Gunariya (Gaya district, Bihar) inscription[59] dated in the ninth regnal year of Mahendrapala, who is given the epithet *Gunacharita.* Another inscription dated in the fifteenth regnal year of Mahendrapala is engraved on a stone image of Surya found at Mahisantosh in west Dinajpur district.[60]

The study of these records dated in various regnal years of Mahendrapala shows that the Pratihara empire at this time comprised a large territory extending form Gujarat in the west to Bengal in the east. On the basis of epigraphic records, R.C. Majumdar suggested that Mahendrapala, armed with resources of the vast Pratihara empire, followed up the victory over the Palas with relentless severity. This success of Pratihara was due to declining power of the Palas during the later half of the ninth century AD. This century also witnessed the emergence of the two former dependent kingdoms of Assam and Orissa. The Pratihara hold over Magadha also did not last long, as an inscription of Narayanapala mentions the region of northern Bengal and Bihar under the Palas around AD 908. Mahendrapala's hold over the region of Kathiawar is evident from Una records. The Chalukya family of Avanivarman was in-charge of the Kathiawar region. They had a faithful record of allegiance to the Pratihara family of Kanauj, and it continued to maintain cordial relations even in the turbulent period of Ramabhadra's reign. Bhoja and Mahendrapala enjoyed authority over Gujarat with the support and allegiance of the Chalukya feudatories.

The Pehova records confirmed that east Punjab and present-day Haryana continued to be the part of the Pratihara empire under Mahendrapala.

Mahendrapala is also known to us as the patron of literature. The famous poet and dramatist Rajashekhara was considered his guru and spiritual teacher. His magnum opus *Kavyamimansa* provides exhaustive geographical and cultural information of the country and its kingdom. Mahendrapala's last known date is AD 907-08 and he probably died not long afterwards. The succession to the throne after him is a matter of dispute and the available data lead to confusion.

Mahendrapala's Successors

According to R.C. Majumdar,[61] Mahendrapala had at least two sons by two queens—Bhoja II and Vinayakapala, both of whom ruled after him. Bhoja II certainly ascended throne before Vinayakapala, one of whose known dates is AD 931. Mahipala, another son of Mahendrapala, is known to have been ruling in AD 914–17 while

a king Kshitipala is known to be the father of King Devapala, ruling in AD 948–499. On the basis of epigraphic records, a genealogy of Pratihara rulers, who ruled after Mahendrapala, may be drawn up as follows:

1. Bhoja II (son of Mahendrapala);
2. Mahipala;
3. Vinayakapala;
4. Kshitipala;
5. Devapala (son of Kshitipala).

It is generally held that Bhoja II succeeded his father Mahendrapala, but after a brief reign of four or five years, gave way for his brother Mahipala, who was also known as Kshitipala and various other names like Vinayakapala or Herambapala. It has been suggested by some scholars that Mahipala rebelled against his brother and usurped the throne. However, there is no clear evidence to show that there was a struggle for succession to the throne.

Mahipala

After his accession, Mahipala tried his best to regain the lost prestige of Pratihara family. There was no strong adversary to stand in his way as the Chedi ruler was dead and Indra III of the Rashtrakuta dynasty was busy in the south. The poet Rajashekhara continued to enjoy the patronage under Mahipala. He wrote about his patron that, this ruler of Aryavarta was thus left free to expand his empire in different directions from Kalinga in the east to Kathiawar in the west and from Kuluta in the north to Kuntala in the south. He was joined by his subordinates and allies in his triumphant march. The other kings mentioned by the famous poet were those of Murala, Mekala, Kerala, Kuntala and Kalinga, who were conquered by Mahipala. There might be some poetic exaggeration in Rajashekhara's description, but it seems that probably Mahipala availed the opportunity to conquer the south and east regions due to the weak positions of the Rashtrakutas and Palas, respectively. Even the Arab historian Al-Masudi admits the greatness of this ruler of Kanauj.[62] He was rich in horses and camels, and maintained four armies in four directions, each numbering 700,000 or 900,000 men.

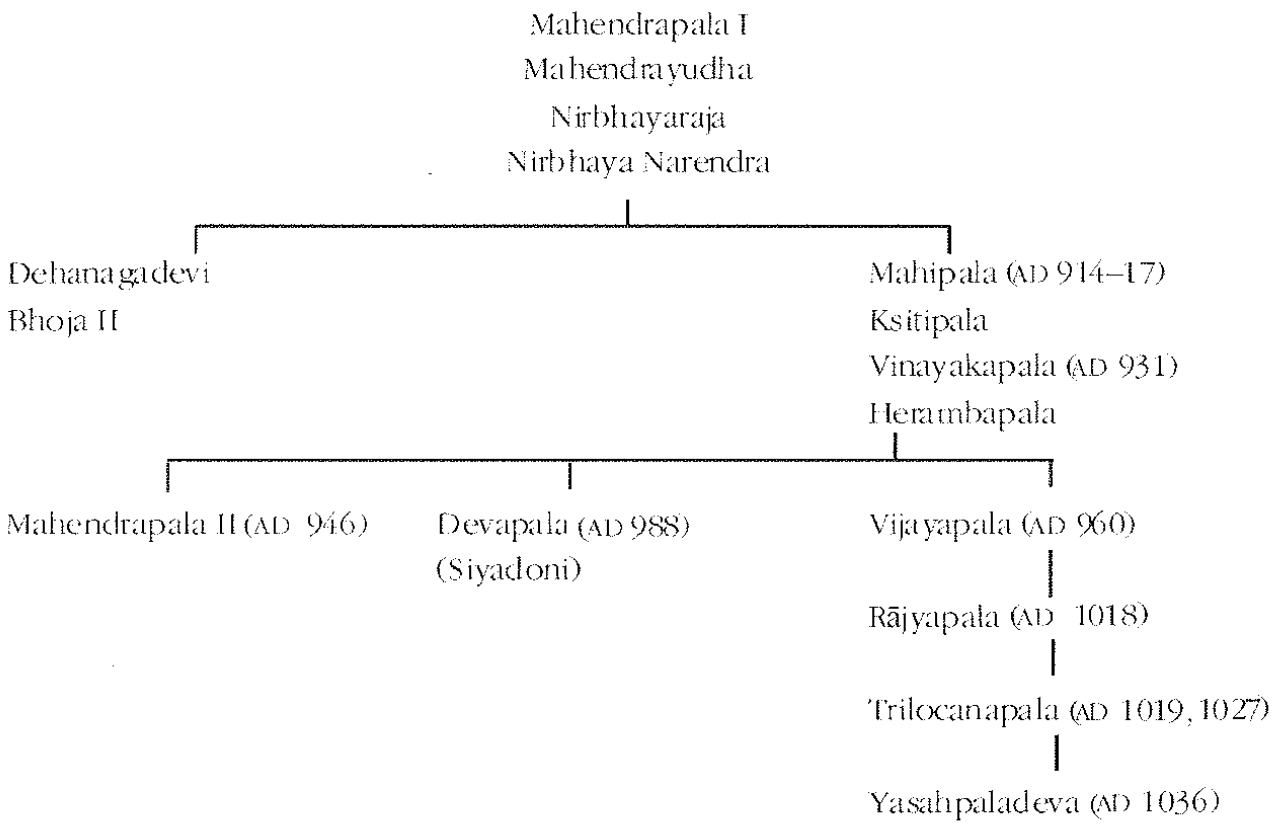
The conquest of south seems to be alluded in the *Chandakusikam* of Kshemesvara. This Kshemesvara is said to have flourished under the patronage of Mahipala. The three important *Samantas* and allies of Pratiharas were the Champas of Kathiawar,[63] Kalachuri of Gorakhpur[64] and the Guhilas of Jaipur,[65] who owed allegiance to the family even in troubled times. Two other *samanta* families—Chahamanas of Sakambhari[66] and the Chandellas of Jejakabhukti[67]—were important. On the basis of epigraphical and literary records,[68] we cannot determine with certainty whether Mahipala succeeded in recovering all the territories he had lost.[69] Probably he ruled for a period of about 17-18 years. He seems to have lost his throne as a result of a conspiracy hatched by Chedi and Rashtrakuta rulers. Mahipala finally retrieved the situation with the help of Harsadeva, the Chandella ruler.

After Mahipala, the list of rulers who ruled over Kanauj is very confusing. In the following page are given two genealogical tables as suggested by B.N. Puri.[70]

As against this genealogy, the other view suggesting separate identities of Ksitipala, Mahipala and Vinayakapala may be drawn as follows:

Vinayakapala

Vinayakapala, son of Mahendrapala from Mahidevi, was ruling from Kanauj in the vs 988

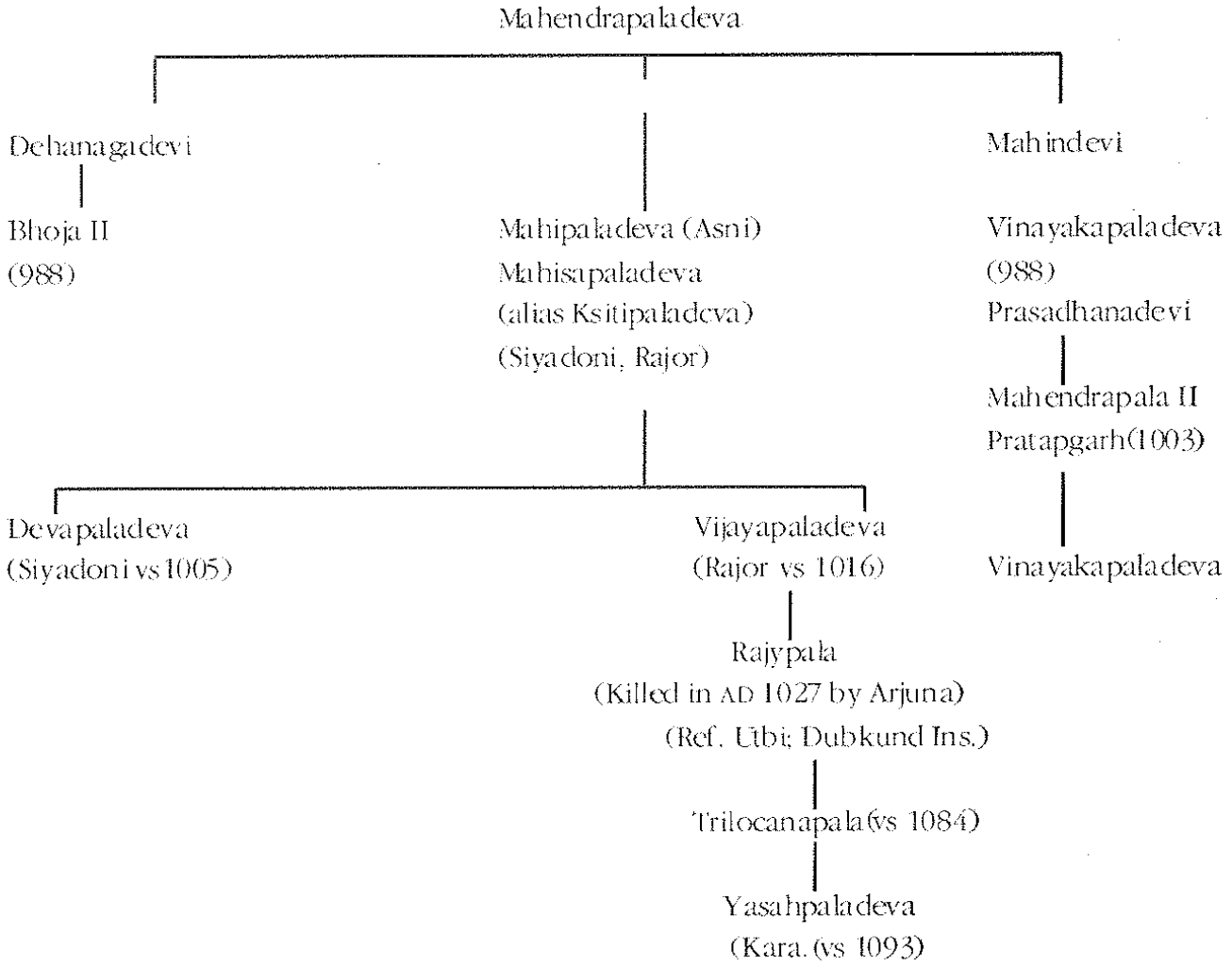


(AD 931). This is confirmed by the *bhumidana* issued from Mahodaya, which mentions his name.

The information available from the Bengal Asiatic Society plate of vs 998[71] and Rakhetra stone inscription dated to vs 999-1000[72] suggests that Vinayakapala ruled at least from AD 931–43. The reference of Vinayakapala in the Pratapgarh inscription dated in vs 1003 of his son Mahendrapala II[73] suggests that this line was enjoying the sovereign status at Kanauj. The Gurjara Pratihara empire during the time of Vinayakapaladeva seems to have extended from Varanasi in the east to Gwalior in the west. In the south-west it included Ujjain, which was ruled by Madhava, the *samanta* and governor of Ujjain. Srisarman was the Commander-in-Chief and was carrying on the affairs of the state from Mandapika (present-day Mandor). These facts are recorded in the Pratapgarh inscription of the time of the Cahamana Indraraja whose family was owing allegiance to the Pratihara family.

Mahendrapala II

The Pratabgarh inscription[74] describes him as the son of Vinayakapaladeva by Queen Prasadhanadevi of the Devatharddi family. He seems to have ruled for less than five years, as Devapala, son of Ksitipala, is reported to be ruling in AD 948 (vs 1005). The inscription was issued from Mahodaya and it records that at the request of one Dhanasura, Mahendrapala II bestowed the village of Kharaparapadraka in the holding of Tala Vargika Harisada, and situated in the vicinity of Ghonta-Varsika in the western Pathaka of Dasapur (Mandsaur), upon the Goddess Vatayaksinidevi, whose shrine was connected with the Matha of Hari Risisvara. The hold of Kanauj over this region was undisturbed and Madhava, son of Damodara, was acting as



Mahadandanayaka, *samanta*, and *tantrapala*, and his Commander-in-Chief *Baladhikrita*, Sri Sarman was carrying on the affairs of the state at Mandapika or Mandor. This record is important as it shows the continuation of administrative machinery intact in the time of Mahendrapala II, without the diminution in size of the Pratihara empire. Kanauj continued to be the capital city from where such charters were issued, but afterwards the process of decline was rapid. It is likely that the feudatories declared their independence during this period of uncertainty and instability, as certain details of a controversial nature are issued by the later Pratihara records.

The Siyadoni inscription mentions Devapala, son of Kshitipala, ruling in AD 948 (vs 1005). It is interesting to note that in this record, there is no reference either to Vinayakapala or to his successor Mahendrapala of the Pratapgarh inscription. R.S. Tripathi is of the opinion that the omission of Mahendrapala's name might be due to the extreme shortness of his reign, or under the assumption that their relations were unfriendly.[75] This is not the solitary instance of the omission of collateral's name. The other inscriptions of later Pratihara rulers also ignore the names of members of other families or of collateral lines. Possibly, there was always a tussle for succession causing insecurity, and that

accounts for the curtailment of their reigns. This could as well have provided a favourable opportunity for the *samantas* to declare their independence.

On the basis of Chandella records, B.N. Puri proposed that this Devapala might have been a Gurjara-Pratihara *samanta*, as there were several other Pratihara families and the Kanauj line of imperial Pratiharas did not involve itself in the quarrels of *samantas*.[76]

Vinayakapaladeva II

Vinayakapaladeva does not figure anywhere in the dynastic list of Gurjara-Pratihara or any other inscription except the Khajuraho inscription of Dhanga, which refers to one Vinayakapaladeva protecting the earth. Kielhorn, who edited this inscription, expressed his inability to trace out the relationship between this ruler Vinayakapaladeva and the Chandella ruler Dhanga. B.N. Puri is of the opinion that this Vinayakapaladeva was the son of Mahendrapaladeva and succeeded his uncle Devapaladeva about AD 950.[77] It is difficult to determine the duration of his reign, but Vijayapaladeva, son of Kshitipaladeva, a brother of Devapaladeva, was on the Kanauj throne in AD 919 (VS 1016). In between these rulers was Mahipala.

Mahipala II

The identification of this ruler is also a controversial issue. The only inscription found at Ukhamandir-Bayana (Bharatpur)[78] records the construction of a temple of Vishnu by a queen named Chitralekha during the reign of a king named Mahipala whose family is not mentioned in this record. The territories of Bayana were part of the Pratihara empire. Thus, the Mahipala of Bayana record was either a Gurjara Pratihara ruler of Kanauj or a *samanta* of Pratihara king.

Vijayapala

The reference to Vijayapala and his successors is provided by the Rajor inscription of Mathanadeva,[79] the Jhusi inscription of Trilochanapala[80] and the Kara plate of Maharaja Yasapala.[81] Besides the epigraphical records, the accounts of contemporary Arab historians, especially Biruni and Utbi's records, are helpful. Rajor inscription (Alwar district) is dated in the reign of Vijayapaladeva, successor of Kshitipaladeva, and records the *bhumidana* of *Vamsapotaka Bhoga, Sambaddha* – Vyaghrapataka grama to the god Lacchukesvara Mahadeva. Vijayapala was on the throne of Mahodaya in AD 959 (VS 1016).[82]

The Jhusi inscription of Trilochanapala dated in AD 1027 (VS 1084) records Rajyapala as successor to Vijayapaladeva. The donor of the *bhumidana*, Trilochanapaladeva, is mentioned as the son of Vijayapaladeva. On the occasion of *Makara Sankranti*, the king gave the village of Lebhundaka in the Asurabhaka *Visaya* to six thousand brahmanas belonging to various *gotras*, *pravaras* and different Vedic schools. It is clear from this record that Vijayapala, Rajyapala and Trilochanapala ruled between AD 959 and 1027. Yashpaladeva was the last ruler of this dynasty.

Rajyapala

The role of Rajyapala in stemming the tide of the Turk menaces is not negligible. According to Farishta, when Jayapala had invoked help and dispatched letters seeking succour to the various provinces of India, the rulers of Delhi, Ajmer, Kalanjara and Kanauj assisted him with men and money.[83] This Kanauj king was probably

Rajyapala. Farishta once again recorded that, when Mahmud devised plans in the spring of the year Hijri 399 (AD 1008) to attack the Sahi Kingdom then under Anandpala, this Hindu ruler dispatched ambassadors to all parts of Hindustan appealing for assistance from other Hindu rulers who now considered the expulsion of the Mohammedans from India as a sacred duty.

The king of Kanauj, who had helped earlier Shahi ruler on an earlier occasion, promptly answered the call of his compatriot and sent a huge continent, his example being followed by the Rajas of Ujjain, Gwalior, Kalanjara, Delhi and Ajmer. This united effort of the Hindu states of northern India to check the forces of Islam under Mahmud proved ineffective. Mahmud decided to deal with each of the confederate powers individually.

Historian Utbi, who was secretary to Sultan Mahmud, informs us that on the twentieth day of *Rajab* AH 409 (AD 1018), Mahmud, after crossing the Jamuna, appeared at Baran (Bulandshahr) in the country of Hardat who submitted to the Sultan, renouncing his religion with 10,000 followers.[84] The next target was Kulachand, whose principality was near Baran. He bravely resisted Mahmud dying a martyr's death. The next halt was at Mathura, which was sacked before the Sultan reached Kanauj on the eighth day of Shaban. King Jayapala, hearing of his approach, deserted the city and fled across the Ganges. The Sultan advanced to the fortification of Kanauj, which consisted of seven distinct forts, which were all captured in one day. Utbi does not mention the political consequences of this invasion. Very probably, after the devastation of Kanauj, he left the city. From Kanauj, Mahmud went to Munj, known as the fort of the Brahmans, which offered strong resistance. This was followed by advance towards Asi ruled by Chandella Bhora, one of the chief men and generals of the Hindus. He was always engaged in a career of victory, and at one time, was at war with the Rai of Kanauj. When the Chandella ruler heard of the advance of the Sultan, he lost his heart and took to flight, followed by the demolition of his five forts with the inhabitants buried under the ruins. Utbi futher describes the campaign towards Candarya who resided in the fort of Sharwa, identified by Cunningham with Sirsawa to the east of the Jamuna near Saharanpur. He was an enemy of Puru Jayapala. The Sultan then returned to his capital in the spring of that year.

The end of Rajyapala at the hands of the Chandella king is recorded in the Dubkund inscription of Vikramashah, dated AD 1088 (vs 1145). The Chandella king Vidyadhara probably killed the Pratihara ruler of Kanauj. The old rivalry between the two families was probably the root cause of Rajyapala's destruction at the hands of the Chandella ruler and his allies.

Trilochanpala

The Jhusi inscription mentions the illustrious Trilochanapala, son of Rajyapala.[85] The record is dated AD 1027 (vs 1054). The name of Trilochanapala also occurs in Nizamuddin's *Tabaqat-i-Akbari* describing the invasion in AD 1019-20 (H 410). The high-sounding titles assumed by Trilochanapala in his inscription suggest that he was not a *samanta* of the Chandellas though his territory was lost and his father was killed by Chandella ruler Vidyadhara. He ruled till AD 1027. The Gurjara-Pratihara empire was now confined only to this region. The date of his death is not recorded anywhere nor is there any information about his successor.

YASHAPALADEVA

The Kara inscription[86] dated in AD 1036-37 (VS 1093) records the gift of the *Maharajadhiraja* Yashpaladeva. The exact relationship of Yashpala with Trilochanapala cannot be determined but, it seems that the former succeeded the latter either as his legitimate successor or as an usurper. He is styled only as a *Maharaja,* which might suggest that he was content to be a local ruler in the Allahabad district.

ESTIMATE OF PRATIHARA EMPIRE

The Gurjara-Pratihara empire of Kanauj was founded by Nagabhata and was established through the efforts of Bhoja, Mahendrapala, and Mahipala. The empire at one time expanded from Bay of Bengal in the east to Arabian Sea in the west. It continued in full glory for nearly a century. It was considered the last great empire in northern India, before the Muslim conquest, in its extent and duration of time. The credit of Pratihara rulers lies in their successful resistance of the invasion of Turks from west and the attacks of Rashtrakutas from the south.

During the Turkish invasions from the days of Junaid (AD 725) to those of Mahumd of Ghazni, the Pratiharas stood as the bulwark of India's defense against the aggression of the Muslims. The bravery and resistance of Pratihara rulers is frankly recognized by the Arab historians. It is also cited as one of the reasons for the slow progress of Muslim invaders in India, as compared to their rapid advance in other parts of the world. It was the power of the Pratiharas that effectively checked the progress of the Muslims beyond the confines of Sindh, for nearly three hundred years.

The tripartite struggle that dominated the political and military horizon of India for more than hundred years was due to the role played by Pratihara rulers in providing resistance to the Palas from the east and the Rashtrakutas from the south. In the case of each empire, they rose like the waves of the sea reaching to the highest point only to break down. In this, the Pratiharas had played a longer spell of success than either of their rivals.

The success of Pratihara lies in the long succession of able rulers such as Vatsaraja, Nagabhata II, Bhoja, Mahendrapala, and Mahipala who ruled almost uninterruptedly for a century and a half with a short break for three years. They created the tradition of a royal glory, which long endured and survived many rude shocks of Muslim rule in India. The successive states that emerged after the decline of the Pratiharas successfully carried on this tradition. Rajashekhara, the great Indian poet of the period under study, refers to his royal patron as the 'Maharajadhiraja *of* Aryavarta'.

SUCCESSORS OF PRATIHARAS

During the reign of Vijayapaladeva and his son Rajyapaladeva, who ruled from AD 959 to 1019, the Pratihara empire steadily began to decline. Several states, formerly owing allegiance to the Pratihara families, declared their independence. In the west, Gujarat emerged independent under Mularaja of the Chalukya family. He had set up a kingdom at Anahilavada (Anahilla-Pataka) that included Gujarat with the south-western province of Saurashtra.

In central India, Chandella kingdom was established by Dhanga by taking full advantage of the declining power of the Pratiharas and by defeating the king of Kanauj. The Khajuraho inscription of Dhanga described his kingdom extending as far as Kalanjara, and as far as Bhasvat situated on the banks of the river Malava, up to the banks of river Kalindi and to the frontiers of the Chedi country, and even as far as the mountain Gopadri.

The Sas-bahu inscription attritibutes the conquest of Gwalior to the Kacchapaghata prince Vajradaman. It is clear from the records that Gwalior was lost to the Chandellas, and the Kacchapaghata prince Vajradaman was probably acting as *samanta* of Chandella ruler, Dhanga. The loss of the fort of Gopadri (Gwalior) was a heavy blow to the prestige of Pratiharas due to its strategic location.

The Chedis occupied the territory between the Chandellas in the north and the Chalukyas in the south. Kokkalladeva I, the great Chedi ruler, actively participated in the affairs of Kanuaj and his protégé Bhoja II was on the Kanauj throne for a couple of years. The Chedis might have made an alliance with the Rashtrakutas and Chandellas against the Pratiharas.

The region of Malwa under the Paramaras was another rising state in central India. The Paramaras emerged as the *samanta* of Rashtrakutas. The Pratapgarh inscription of Pratihara king Mahendrapala II dated AD 946 records that Madhava was *samanta* and governor at Ujjayini, confirming the Pratihara rule over the region. The Paramara records of AD 949–73 (VS 1005–29) show that Siyaka-Harsa of the Paramara dynasty governed Malwa. This *Mahamandalika Chudamani Maharajadhirajapati* Siyaka II was a *samanta* of *Paramabhattaraka Maharajadhiraja Paramesvara* Akalavarsa identified with Krishna II of Rashtrakula dynasty. The Udaipur *prasasti* of Siyaka-Harsa records that he took away the wealth of Khottiga and had many victories over the Karnatas, Latas, Cholas and Chedis. There is no reference to the powers in the north. In this situation, the Paramaras seem to have declared themselves independent of the Rashtrakutas and by conquering the region of Malwa, they ended the hold of the Pratiharas over the region. The Indore plate of Paramaras mention three predecessors of Vakapatirajadeva—Krisnaraja, Vairasimtra and Siyakadeva with usual titles of *Parambhattaraka Maharajadhiraja Paramesvara*, thereby suggesting the independent status of Paramaras.

The declining power and confusion in the Pratihara family over succession was responsible for the defections of many *samanta* families.

The northwest India under the Shahi kings faced repeated invasions of the Arabs and that also threatened the political stability of Pratihara rulers. In this political situation, the Gurjara empire was confined to the Ganga-Yamuna doab. The final blow to the Pratiharas came with the Ghaznis invasion from the north-west.

II. ADMINISTRATION OF GURJARA- PRATIHARAS

The epigraphical records of the Gurjara-Pratiharas and their contemporary *samanta* throw light on their administrative system.[87]

KINGSHIP

King was the head of the state. The kingship was hereditary and rule of primogeniture was followed. The Arab historians Al Masudi and Sulaiman describe that the royalty was limited to the descendants of one family and never passed to another.

The kings of the Pratihara family assumed high-sounding imperial titles in view of their political achievements, and successfully overcoming difficulties and external pressures.[88] The epigraphs inform us that Vatsaraja was the first king who chose the epithets *Maharajadhiraja* and *Paramesvara*. From Nagabhata II onwards, the Gurjara kings invariably use the set of titles—*Paramabhattaraka Maharajadhiraja* and *Paramesvara*, while King Bhoja was addressed as *Adivaraha* in Gwalior inscription.[89]

As an administrative head of the state, the king performed three functions—executive, judicial and military. He had no legislative power except to issue occasional *Rajasasanas* or royal edicts by way of administrative measures. The laws were (as defined in *Smritis* and by the thinkers) already there, believed to be ordained and the king had merely to execute them. The king also made appointments on the higher positions, looked into the state finances, granted audience to envoys and collected secret information from spies. He appears to have been considered as the fountain of justice. He was also the head of army and deliberated over plans of offence and defense with his Mahasenapati or Senapati.[90]

There is no direct reference to Mantriparisad or the council of ministers, but a perusal of the list of officials in the records suggests that after all, the machinery was not a one-man's show but a collective effort of the king and his ministers.

Chief Queen

Next to the king was the chief queen (*Agra* or *Pattamahisi).* The queen received a handsome allowance for her maintenance and acted as a regent in case her husband expired leaving a minor to succeed him. She appears to have had some royal prerogatives of donating land and was involved in other public welfare activities.

Crown Prince (Yuvaraja)

The Yuvaraja held the status of a *Panchamahasabda Samanta.* He had an honoured position in the realm. Like the chief queen, he seems to have been invested with certain royal prerogatives. When the ruling king was old and retiring or during the religious disposition, the heir-apparent perhaps exercised almost all powers of the ruling monarch.

State Officials

The Pratihara king was assisted by a number of functionaries to carry on the day-to-day administration. Their epigraphs refer to the following officials:[91]

1. *Mahamantrin*: (Chief Minister) He was the chief advisor to the king.
2. *Purohita*: (Royal preceptor) He helped the king in performing religious duties.
3. *Rajamatya*: Minister of the king, who served as a link between the king and his council.[93]
4. *Mahakumaramatya*: Chief Minister.[94]
5. *Mahasandhivigrahika*: Chief Officer for peace and war.[95]
6. *Mahsenadhipati*: Commander-in-Chief.[96]
7. *Mahadandanayaka*: Chief criminal judge.[97]
8. *Mahapratihara*: Chief Chamberlain.[98]
9. *Mahasamanta*: Chief Officer over the *Sardars.*[99]
10. *Mahaksapatalika*: Chief Keeper of records.[100]
11. *Mahadharmadhyaksa*: Chief justice.[101]
12. *Mahamudradhikrta*: In-charge of mint.[102]
13. *Mahabhogika*: In-charge of revenue.[103]
14. *Dausadhasadhanika*: Policeman.[104]
15. *Dandapasika*: Policeman.[105]
16. *Dandoddharanika*: Judical Officer.[106]
17. *Chauroddharanika*: Officer entrusted with the pursuit of robbers.[107]
18. *Dandika*: Jailor.
19. *Dasaparadhika*: Magistrate or in-charge of ten offences.[108]
20. *Dutapresanika*: Spies.
21. *Baladhikrta*: Superintendent of the forces.[109]

22. *Baladhyaksa*: Superintendent of the forces.[110]
23. *Gaulmika*: Head of the branch of army.[111]
24. *Chatabhata*: Irregular or regular soldiers.[112]
25. *Rajaputra*: Kshatriya prince related to royalty.[113]
26. *Yuktaka*: Accountant.[114]
27. *Niyuktaka*: Deputy Accountant.[115]
28. *Tantrapala*: In-charge of affairs.[116]
29. *Kayastha/Karanika*: Scribe/writer of legal documents.[117]
30. *Bhandagarika*: Superintendent of the stores.
31. *Antahpurika*: Superintendent of the Seraglio.
32. *Antaranga*: Confidential servant.[118]
33. *Bhisaka*: Royal physican.
34. *Naimittika*: Astrologer.
35. *Dutuka*: Messenger.[119]
36. *Duta*: Envoy.
37. *Sasthadhikrta*: In-charge of revenue.[120]
38. *Hastyasvagomahisyajavikadhyaksa*: Superintendent of elephants, horses, cow, buffalos, goat and sheep.[121]
39. *Naukadhyaksa*: Superintendent of boats.[122]
40. *Dasagramika*: Officer in-charge of groups of ten villages.[123]
41. *Ksetrapa*: Supervisor of cultivators.[124]
42. *Vasapakas*: In-charge of guest houses.
43. *Dramgika*: Officer in-charge of town.[125]
44. *Akaradhikara Purusas*: Officers in-charge of mines.
45. *Karyita*: Overseer.[126]
46. *Rajarajanaka*: Subordinate chief.[127]

Provincial Administration

The Pratihara empire was divided into a number of administrative divisions. The epigraphs used the terms like *visaya, bhumi mandala, bhukti,* and *pathaka.*[128] The empire was divided into Sravasti-Bhukti, Kanyakubja-bhukti, Gurjaratra-bhukti, Pundravardhana bhukti and the in-charge officer was designated as *Rastrapati, Rajasthaniya* or *Uparika-Maharaja.*

The provincial governors were either members of the royal house, local chiefs or imperial officials.[129] They enjoyed the status of *Mahasamantas* and bore the title of *Raja.* The provincial governors were assisted by a number of subordinate officers. Among these, *Vyavaharin* or controlling officer, *Uparikamatya* minister attached to the governors, *Dutaka* Messengers conveyed the orders of the kings to them; *Kottapala* was the guardian of the fort and *Baladhikrta* was in-charge of military.

Mandala

Next to the *bhukti* was the *mandala.* The head of the *mandala* was Mandalesvara.[130] The Pratihara records mention four *mandalas,* i.e. Kalanjara (Branch), Sravasti (Dighwa-Dubauli), Saurastra (Una), and Kausambi (Kara).[131]

Visaya (District)

The *bhuktis* were further divided into a number of districts called *visayas.* Pratihara records mention Asurabhaka-*Visaya*; Valayika-*Visaya,* Dendavanaka-*Visaya,* and Varanasi-*Visaya.*[132] The term *bhogha* appears to have been used sometimes in the same sense. The in-charge of *Visaya* was known as *Visayapatis* and the head of *bhoga* called *bhogapati.* The *Visayapatis* were probably appointed by the provincial governors and approved by the king.[133] They were

associated with the council of *Visaya-mahattaras*. He had his sets of officers, viz. *Dasaparadhika, Chauroddharanika Dandika, Dandapasika, Dandanayaka, Saulika Ksetrapa, Prantapala* and *Kottopala*.

The *Visayapatis* appear to have exercised considerable revenue powers as they are mentioned in the copperplate charters related to *bhumidana*. They must have been responsible to the provincial governors (*Rastrapatis*) or central government for the revenue of their districts. Their headquarters were perhaps called *Adhisthana* or *Pattana*. Another administrative unit was the *pathaka* and it was lower than the *visayas*.[134] The administrative unit was further divided into *agraharas* or *tehsils*.[135] They consisted of a number of villages.

Village or *grama* was the lower-most administrative unit. It seems to have fixed sites and boundaries. The head of the *grama* was called Gramapati, Gamagamika, Mahatara, and Mahattamaas as mentioned in inscriptions.[136] The headman was perhaps appointed or recognized by the state. They administered the *grama* with the assistance of a village council comprising the village elders.

Municipalities and Guilds

The Siyadoni inscription[137] records that the affairs of the town were managed by an assembly of five called *Panchakula* and by a committee of the two appointed from time to time by the town. Every trade organization had its guild and no man could offend the guild with impunity.[138] The guilds of oil-millers, gardeners, stone-cutters, sugarcane crushers, horse-dealers, betel-sellers, etc. are mentioned in the records of the Pratihara time.

Military Organization

The military machinery of the Pratiharas was very strong and efficient. Arab traveller Sulaiman described that the king of Jurz (Gurjara) maintained numerous forces and no other Indian prince had so fine a cavalry.[139] Al Masudi informs us that the Gurjara Pratihara used to maintain a large army garrison in the south and north, east and west, in order to deal promptly with prospective attacks on all the fronts.[140]

The army appears to have consisted of elephants, horses and infantry, and state-built forts for the defence of the country.

Important Inscriptions

1. Gwalior Stone Inscription of Bhoja.[141]
2. Jodhpur Stone Inscription of Bauka.[142]
3. Chatsu Inscription of the Guhilot chief, Baladitya.[143]
4. Two Inscriptions of Chalukya chiefs of the time of Mahendrapala.[144]
5. Kahla Plate of Kalachuri Sodhava.[145]
6. Harsha Stone Inscription of the Chahamana Vigraharaja.[146]
7. Siyadoni Inscriptions.[147]
8. Asni Inscription of Mahipala.[148]
9. Bengal Asiatic Society's Copperplate of Vinayakapala.[149]
10. Partabgarh Inscription of Mahendrapala II.[150]
11. Rajorgarh Inscription of Vijayapala.[151]
12. Barah Copperplate of Bhoja.[152]
13. Daulatapura Copperplate of Bhoja.[153]
14. Gwalior Inscription of Bhoja.[154]
15. Buchkala inscription of the time of Nagabhata.[155]

16. Deogarh Jain Pillar Inscription of the time of Bhojadeva.[156]
17. Ahar Inscription of Bhojadeva.[157]
18. Pehova Inscription of the time of Bhojadeva.[158]
19. Sagartal Inscription (*Prasasti*) of Bhoja.[159]
20. Una Plate of the time of Mahendrayudhadeva.[160]
21. Dighwa Dubauli Plate of Mahendrapaladeva.[161]
22. Parharpur Stone Pillar Inscription of Mahendrapala.[162]
23. Haddala Plates of the time of Mahipaladeva.[163]
24. Asni Inscription of the time of Mahipaladeva.[164]
25. Jhusi Plate of the time of Trilochanpaladeva.[165]
26. Kara (now) Calcutta Museum inscription of Yashpala.[166]

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